



COLUMN ONE

A life of violence led him to God



FATHER CESAR GALAN makes his rounds visiting and praying for patients in the intensive care unit at St. Francis Medical Center, where the former gang member himself was treated after a shooting in 2001.

Photographs by CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

Cesar Galan belonged to a street gang in Los Angeles before a shooting left him paralyzed and changed the way he saw the world. Now he goes by Father.

By Harriet Ryan

At St. Francis Medical Center, a Lynwood trauma hospital serving poor, mostly Latino parts of southeast Los Angeles, Father Cesar Galan begins his shift as chaplain in the intensive care unit.

Moving from bedside to bedside, he listens to patients' fears, prays with them and, if they are Catholic, as most are, offers to hear their confessions. Many eagerly unburden themselves, but some say they are beyond forgiveness. *My sins are too bad, they tell him. God could not want anything to do with a person like me.*

In these moments, Galan might be tempted to pour out his own life story. He might say he knows they are wrong — not from doctrine or Scripture alone, but from the .38-caliber bullets he carries inside his body, [See Priest, A8]

A wider LAFD problem: An aging fleet

Broken vehicles were cited in Palisades fire fight, but reliance on older equipment may be issue, records show.

By ALENE TCHEKMEDYAN

After the Palisades fire ignited, top brass at the Los Angeles Fire Department were quick to say that they were hampered by broken fire engines and a lack of mechanics to fix them.

If the roughly 40 fire engines that were in the shop had been repaired, they said, the battle against what turned out to be one of the costliest and most destructive disasters in Los Angeles history might have unfolded differently.

Then-Fire Chief Kristin Crowley cited the disabled engines as a reason fire officials didn't dispatch more personnel to fire-prone areas as the winds escalated, and why they sent home firefighters who showed up to help as the blaze raged out of control. The department, she said, should have had three times as many mechanics.

But many of the broken engines highlighted by LAFD officials had been out of service for many months or even years — and not necessarily for a lack of mechanics, according to a Times review of engine work orders as of Jan. 3, four days before the fire.

What's more, the LAFD had dozens of other engines that could have been staffed and deployed in advance of the fire.

[See Engines, A11]

Another measure to deter homeless

'Annoying' chirping box is being tested out at a West Hollywood shopping center.

By NATHAN SOLIS

Some customers walking out of the West Hollywood Trader Joe's wear annoyed looks on their faces, and it has nothing to do with rising grocery prices.

The source of the irritation is a small blue box installed in a stairwell leading to the market, the latest tactic used by property owners to deter homeless people from camping out in the area.

The motion-activated device chatters like a loud, anxious cricket as people pass by the shopping center. "It's so annoying," Jeffrey Howard said as he left the market with his groceries. "It's like an alarm from a smoke detector that you're just waiting for somebody to [See Device, A7]"



DAVID PAUL MORRIS Bloomberg

TRAVELERS go through security at San Francisco International Airport in May.

Travel season faces disruptions amplified by Trump's policies

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration invited travel industry executives to the White House in May for a meeting on federal plans for the 2026 World Cup, a landmark event that under normal circumstances would draw massive international tourism to the

United States. It was a welcome gathering by President Trump and his team for an industry eager to capitalize on a rare opportunity and capture tourism dollars.

Welcome, at least, until Vice President JD Vance cracked a joke.

"We'll have visitors from close to 100 countries — we want them to come, we want them to celebrate, we want

them to watch the games. But when the time is up, they'll have to go home. Otherwise, they'll have to talk to Secretary Noem," Vance said, referring to the Homeland Security secretary and head of border enforcement.

Vance's remarks, while taken in jest, fell flat in a room filled with experts more keenly aware than [See Travel, A7]

Hurdles she faced at animal shelters

Former L.A. agency head says she felt powerless amid dire staffing problems.

By DAKOTA SMITH

Staycee Dains was about a month into her job overseeing the Los Angeles city animal shelters when an employee openly defied her.

Dains asked the employee to clean a kennel. Instead, the employee picked up a

hose and sprayed a dog in the face, Dains said.

Dains thought the employee should be fired, but she said the city's personnel department recommended five days of leave.

Mayor Karen Bass hired Dains in June 2023 after promising to make L.A. "a national model for animal welfare" by turning around its troubled shelters, where some dogs live in overcrowded and dirty kennels and volunteers have complained that animals some- [See Shelters, A12]

Chinese, Taiwanese citizens arrested

Thirty-six accused of being in country illegally are seized in a raid at underground club. CALIFORNIA, B1

Yes, we have no Bananas tickets

Barnstorming baseball team with huge appeal visits Angel Stadium for two sell-outs. SPORTS, D1

Weather

Not as warm. L.A. Basin: 80/62. B10

Business A14
Opinion Voices A16

Banks, Biel doing it for themselves

Stars of "The Better Sister" discuss series and decades in industry. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

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